

The Pre-Snap Phase: Shifts, Motion, Cadence, and Audibles

The fifteen seconds after the coach's voice goes dead: why players move, why they freeze, why the quarterback shouts, and what each side is trying to learn before the ball is snapped.

Fourth-and-2 near midfield. The offense breaks its huddle and lines up with the tight end on the right. A beat later he jogs across to the left side while one receiver steps up to the line and another steps back, and then, for one long second, nobody on the offense moves at all. A receiver starts trotting across the formation behind the line; on the other side of the ball a cornerback trots with him, step for step. The quarterback points at a linebacker and shouts a number, then a word, then barks "*Hut!*" so loudly that a defensive tackle twitches across the line. Flag. Five yards, first down. Nobody has touched the ball, and the offense has already won the snap. This chapter is about those fifteen seconds: why players move, why they freeze, why the quarterback shouts, and what both teams are trying to find out before anything "happens."

You'll be able to...

- Tell a shift from motion on a broadcast, and say whether what you just saw was legal: one man moving at the snap, not toward the line, after everyone was set for a full second.
- Explain what the quarterback's cadence is for, why a hard count works, and why a road team switches to a silent count.
- Name the four pre-snap penalties you'll see most often (false start, offside, encroachment and neutral zone infraction), who gets flagged, and why some stop the play and one doesn't.
- Recognize an audible, a check, a kill call and a dummy call, and explain why a quarterback can only change the play to something his team prepared.
- Spot the defense moving before the snap (safeties walking down, linebackers creeping into the line, fronts sliding over) and say what it might be hiding.
- List what each side is trying to learn before the snap, and use that list to watch the next play.

Fifteen seconds without a coach

In *What a Play Really Is* we followed a play call from the coach's call sheet into the quarterback's helmet, and left it at the moment the radio cuts out: **15 seconds** on the play clock. From there to the snap, nobody on the sideline can talk to the players. That last stretch, usually ten seconds or so for a huddling offense, belongs to the twenty-two people on the field.

Remember why it matters. Both play-callers chose their calls *blind* to each other. The offense doesn't know what defense is coming; the defense doesn't know what play is coming. Once both sides line up, each can finally see the other, and each tries to do two things at once: **learn something** about the other side's call, and **hide something** about its own. Everything in this chapter (the shifting, the motion, the shouting, the defenders creeping around) is one of those two jobs.

The figure lays out the order of events. Not every snap uses every step: plenty of plays go from "set" straight to the snap. But when you see movement before a snap, it comes in this order, and each step has a rule attached.

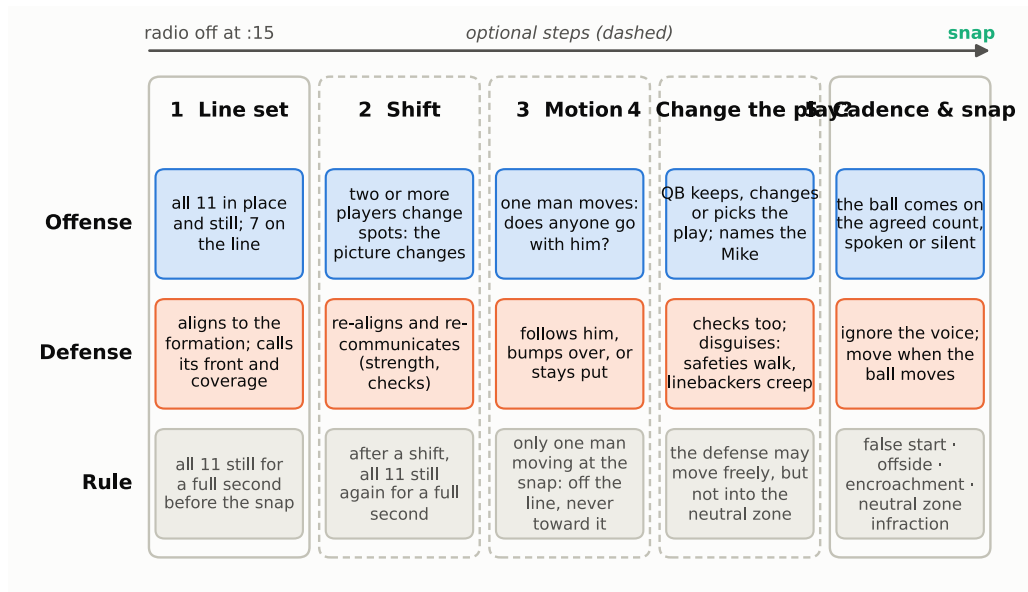


Figure 1: The pre-snap phase, from the moment the offense lines up to the snap. The middle three steps (dashed) are optional: the offense chooses whether to shift, send a man in motion or change the play. Each step has a matching defensive response and a rule that keeps it fair; the rules section of this chapter explains every line in the bottom row.

One asymmetry jumps out of the bottom row. The offense lives under strict rules about moving; the defense hardly has any, as long as it stays out of a strip about a foot wide around the ball. That isn't an accident, and it is the key to the whole chapter: **the offense knows when the ball will be snapped and the defense doesn't**. Almost every rule below exists to stop the offense from turning that knowledge into an unfair head start, and almost every trick exists to squeeze an advantage out of it anyway.

Getting set: the freeze that makes a snap fair

Before the ball can be snapped, the offense has to be **set**: every player in his spot and **completely still, all eleven at the same time, for at least one full second**.¹ At least seven of them must be on the line of scrimmage, the imaginary line through the ball that neither side may cross before the snap; the rest are “backs” behind it (the full formation rules, and why only the players at the ends of the line can catch passes, are in Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment).

Why insist on a frozen second? Picture football without it. An offense that could keep all eleven players moving right up to the snap could run its blockers at the defense like a rolling start in a race: the ball snaps just as they arrive, and they hit defenders who are standing still. Football tried that, and it was ugly. The rule-makers had already banned the most dangerous “momentum” plays, such as the flying wedge, in the 1890s. The one-second set came later, and it came because of one coach.

i History: Knute Rockne and the one-second stop

In the 1910s and 1920s Notre Dame's offense started each play by **shifting**: the four backs lined up in one arrangement, then hopped together into a new one, the “Notre Dame Box,” and the ball was snapped almost the instant they landed. Knute Rockne, the coach who made the shift famous, was a chemistry instructor turned football innovator who loved anything that moved fast and looked good doing it. The shift worked because the defense couldn't finish adjusting to the new formation before the ball was in play, and the backs were still carrying their momentum into the line.

Rules already said shifting players had to stop, but “stop” was easy to fudge. In 1927 the college rules committee put teeth into it: after a shift, players had to stay stationary in their new positions for about **one second**, and the penalty for an illegal shift went up from five yards to fifteen. Rockne grumbled but accepted it; he admitted the non-stop shift had given his teams an unfair edge, and was mainly relieved the committee hadn't required two seconds, which he thought would have killed everything colorful in the game.² The second survives in every level of football today.

¹NFL Rulebook, Rule 7 (“Ball in Play, Dead Ball, Scrimmage”), Section 4 (“Action at or before the snap”) and Section 5 (“Position of players at the snap”): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. Penalty references as listed in the 2025 rulebook summary: false start (7-4-2), encroachment (7-4-3), neutral zone infraction (7-4-4), offside (7-4-5), illegal shift (7-4-7) and illegal motion (7-4-8), each a loss of five yards: NFL.com, “2025 rulebook, part 2”: <https://www.nfl.com/news/2025-rulebook-part-2>.

The “set” rule also defines the first two penalties in the rulebook’s pre-snap section, both on the offense:

- A **false start** is an offensive player moving after he has set. For the five interior linemen (tackle to tackle) the standard is strict: *any* movement is a foul, even a twitch of the hand, because those are the players closest to the defense, and a lineman who flinches forward is getting a head start on the block. For everyone else, the foul is a quick, sudden movement that imitates the snap. The officials blow the whistle at once, the play never happens, and the offense loses five yards.³
- An **illegal shift** is snapping the ball without the one-second freeze after a shift (more on shifts next): five yards.

Shifts: change the picture, then freeze

A **shift** is two or more offensive players changing positions at the same time before the snap. After a shift, the freeze starts over: all eleven players must be set together for a full second before the ball can be snapped.⁴

Watch the animation (or, in print, the frame strip). The offense starts with its tight end on the right. It shifts him across to the left; at the same time the receiver on the left steps back off the line and the receiver on the right steps up onto it. Those two small steps are not decoration. With the tight end now on the left, someone has to be the last man on the line on each side, and the line must still hold seven players; the receivers’ steps keep the formation legal. (If you want to know exactly why, the line-count rules are in Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment.)

²“Report of the American Intercollegiate Football Rules Committee for the Year 1927,” *Dartmouth Alumni Magazine* (Feb. 1928), on the shift rule: players to remain stationary “for a period of approximately one second,” penalty raised from five to fifteen yards, and Rockne’s reaction: <https://archive.dartmouthalumnimagazine.com/article/1928/2/1/report-of-the-american-intercollegiate-football-rules-committee-for-the-year-1927> ; *Britannica*, “Notre Dame box”: <https://www.britannica.com/sports/Notre-Dame-box> . On the 1894 rule changes against mass-momentum plays such as the flying wedge, see Tim Layden, *Blood, Sweat and Chalk* (2010) and the Wikipedia overview “Flying wedge”: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Flying_wedge .

³NFL Rulebook, Rule 7, Section 4 (false start): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> ; Kevin Seifert, ESPN, “Inside Slant: Defining the false start”: https://www.espn.com/blog/nflnation/post/_/id/87051/inside-slant-defining-the-false-start .

⁴NFL Football Operations, video rulebook, “Illegal Shift”: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/illegal-shift/> ; “Illegal Motion”: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/illegal-motion/> (both pages returned errors to automated fetches in October 2026; mirrored at edge-operations.nfl.com).

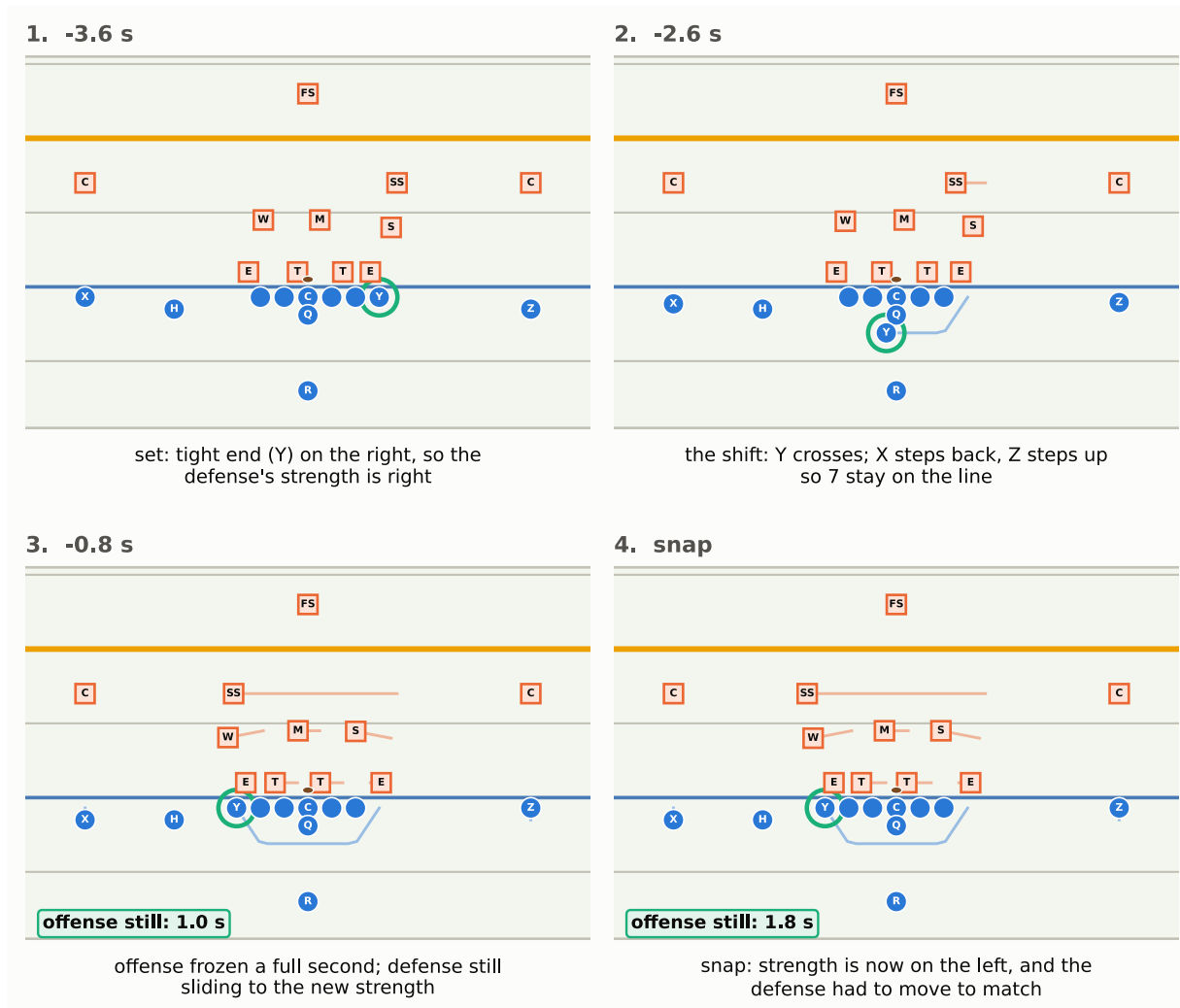


Figure 2: A shift, simulated. (1) The offense is set with its tight end (Y) on the right. (2) Three players move at once: Y crosses behind the quarterback to the left, X steps back off the line and Z steps up onto it. (3) The offense freezes; the counter turns green when it has been still for a full second, the legal minimum. The defense is still sliding: its linemen, linebackers and strong safety (SS) all move over a spot toward the new tight-end side. (4) The snap, with the formation's strength now on the left. Faint lines are where each player has been.

Why do offenses bother? A shift costs time on the play clock, risks a flag if anyone moves early, and gives the quarterback one more thing to manage. What it buys is a **new problem for the defense, presented late**:

- 1. The defense has to re-align and re-communicate.** Defenses set many of their alignments by the formation's *strength*, roughly "the side with the tight end or with more receivers" (formation strength gets its full treatment in Part 2). Move the tight end and the defense's strength call is wrong. Every linebacker and lineman must slide over, and they must all agree on it, with the play clock running and the crowd roaring. In the frame strip, the defense is still adjusting when the offense has been frozen for a full second. A defense that hasn't finished talking at the snap is the easiest kind to block.
- 2. The offense learns how the defense adjusts.** Coaches study film to learn an opponent's rules ("when the tight end moves, the strong safety goes with him"). A shift tests those rules live. If the defense adjusts the way the film said it would, the play-caller knows which answer he already has ready.
- 3. The formation the defense prepared for isn't the one it faces.** The defense's call at the radio cut-off was made against the first formation. A shift can turn a good call into a bad one, and the defense has only seconds to fix it with a check.

⁵Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season (272 games), counting plays by `penalty_type`, including kicking plays: false start 658, offensive holding 672, delay of game 175, defensive offside 141, illegal formation 111, neutral zone infraction 75, illegal shift 48, encroachment 35, illegal motion 12. Play-by-play records the foul on each play; a declined or offset foul on a live-ball play can still appear, which affects offside and holding more than the dead-ball fouls.

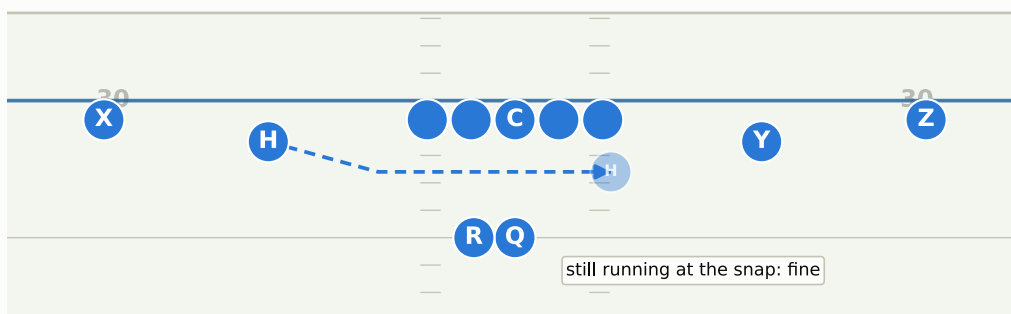
The cost of all this is the obvious one: **it's easy to get wrong**. In the 2025 regular season, officials flagged 48 illegal shifts.⁵ That isn't a lot, but each one is a wasted down and five yards for a play that never happened.

Motion: one man moving

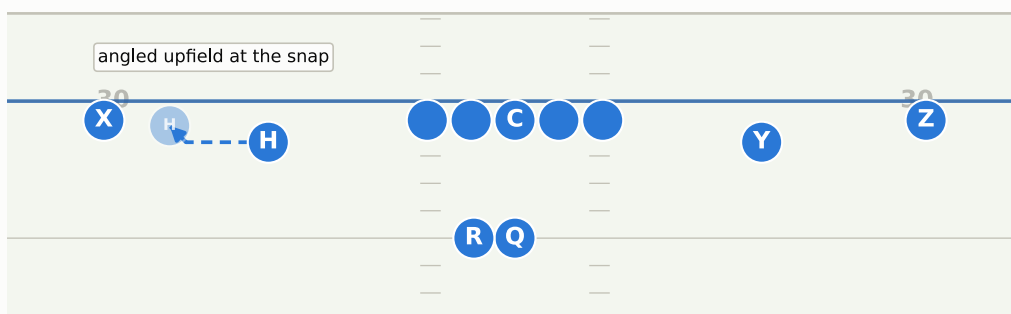
Motion is one offensive player moving before the snap: a receiver jogging across the formation, a running back trotting out wide, a slot receiver sprinting toward the ball just as it is snapped. Unlike a shift, motion doesn't have to stop. The man in motion can still be running when the ball is snapped, as long as he obeys three rules:

1. **Only one player may be moving at the snap.** Two men moving is a shift, and a shift needs the one-second freeze.
2. **He must be off the line of scrimmage**, a "back" in the rulebook's sense, not one of the seven on the line.
3. **He may be moving parallel to the line or away from it, but never toward it.** A man running forward at the snap is an **illegal motion** foul: five yards.⁶

Legal: one man, moving parallel at the snap



Flag: moving toward the line at the snap (illegal motion)



Flag: two men moving at the snap (illegal shift)

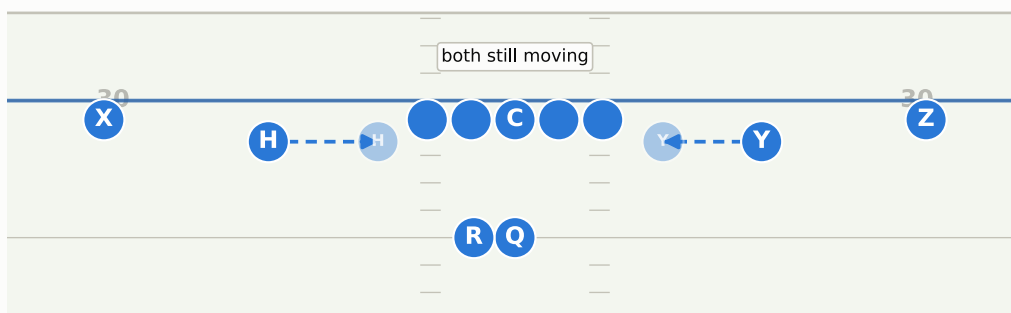


Figure 3: Legal and illegal motion. Dashed lines are pre-snap movement; the faded circle is where the moving player is at the instant of the snap. Top: one man (H) running parallel to the line, still moving at the snap: legal. Middle: the same man has turned upfield and is moving toward the line at the snap: illegal motion. Bottom: two players moving at the snap: that is a shift without the one-second freeze, an illegal shift.

⁶NFL Football Operations, video rulebook, "Illegal Motion": one player who is lined up in the backfield may be in motion at the snap if he is moving parallel to or away from the line of scrimmage; five yards: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/illegal-motion>

The middle panel is drawn with the man angling forward from his own side of the field so you can see the path; the classic illegal-motion flag is a receiver who “cheats” by leaning upfield in his last stride before the snap, a step that’s hard to see live and easy to see on replay.

Why are the rules written this way? The forward-motion ban is the momentum problem again: a receiver running *at* the line when the ball is snapped is a sprinter with a rolling start, already at full speed when he crosses into the defense. (Canadian football draws the line differently: its backs may move in any direction, including forward, before the snap, which is part of why the Canadian game looks so different.⁷) The one-man limit is the shift rule’s other side: one moving player gives the offense flexibility; several would bring back Rockne’s rolling start.

Why motion exists

Motion is one of the oldest tools in the modern game. When Clark Shaughnessy and George Halas’s Chicago Bears beat Washington 73–0 in the 1940 NFL Championship Game with the T formation, a back in motion out of the backfield was part of the show, and the T-with-motion spread through football within a decade.⁸ Today almost every team motions on most plays: PFF’s count of plays with a shift or motion rose from about 38% of NFL snaps in 2014 to 64% in 2025, and every team except the Giants used one on at least half its plays.⁹

Motion and Shifts as Weapons is a whole chapter on what motion buys. In short:

- **Information.** Send a receiver across the formation and watch the defense. If a defender follows him across, the defense is likely in man coverage, where each defender is assigned one receiver to stay with. If defenders just shuffle over a step or two and pass him along, it’s more likely zone coverage, where each defender guards an area. This “man/zone indicator” is a clue, not a guarantee (defenses know you’re looking, and some are built to fake it), and Part 2 shows how to read it.
- **Angles and leverage.** A receiver who starts his route already moving gets off the line faster, and one who moves closer to the ball before the snap has a better angle to block a linebacker or run across the field.
- **Strain.** Like a shift, motion forces the defense to talk and adjust while the clock runs.

Common misconception

“The man in motion has to stop before the snap.” No: that’s a *shift*. One man in motion may be running flat out when the ball is snapped, as long as he’s going sideways or backward. Many modern offenses snap the ball exactly as a receiver sprints across, “motion at the snap,” precisely because a moving receiver is harder to cover and already running at full speed (Motion and Shifts as Weapons). What he can’t do is run *at* the line, and nobody else can be moving with him.

Cadence: who knows when the ball moves

Every play begins the same way: the center snaps the ball. But *when*? That’s the most valuable secret on the field, and it belongs to the offense.

The quarterback controls it with his **cadence**, also called the **snap count**: the spoken signal that tells his team when the ball will be snapped. A typical cadence sounds like “Set... Blue 80, Blue 80... Hut! Hut!” In the huddle the quarterback says which beat the ball is coming on: “on one” means the first *hut*, “on two” the second, “on the first sound” means the instant he makes any noise at all. The words in the middle (“Blue 80”) can carry real messages (a protection change, a “this is live” signal) or be filler, depending on the team.

Why vary the count instead of always snapping on one? Because an offense that always snapped on the same beat would hand the defense its secret. Defensive linemen would simply learn the rhythm and fire off the ball at the same instant as the blockers. Varying the count does two things:

1. **It gives the offensive line a head start.** Five blockers who know the ball is coming on the second *hut* can start moving the instant it arrives. The defenders can’t safely move until they *see* the ball move. A fraction of a second is a big edge for a player whose job is to get his hands on a defender first.

⁷Canadian Football League rulebook (Rule 3, players in motion): in Canadian football any number of backfield players may be in motion at the snap and may move toward the line of scrimmage: <https://www.cfl.ca/cfl-rule-book/>.

⁸Pro Football Hall of Fame, “1940 NFL Championship Game: Bears 73, Redskins 0” and its account of the T formation with a man in motion, devised by George Halas with Clark Shaughnessy: <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1940-1959/1940>.

⁹Daire Carragher, PFF, “NFL pre-snap motion usage reaches new highs across the NFL” (Feb. 23, 2026): shift/motion rate 37.6% (2014) to 63.9% (2025); every team but the Giants at 50% or more in 2025: <https://www.pff.com/news/nfl-pre-snap-motion-usage-reaches-new-highs-across-the-nfl>. PFF’s “shift or motion” measure differs from FTN’s `is_motion` flag in nflverse; don’t mix the two series.

2. **It keeps the defense honest.** If the defense guesses the count and guesses right, it gets the head start instead. If it guesses wrong, it jumps early and gets flagged.

That's why good defensive linemen are coached to ignore the voice entirely and **move on the ball**: to watch the ball (or the center's hand) out of the corner of their eye and go the instant it moves. A defense that reacts to the ball can't be fooled by sound. It is also, by construction, always a split second behind an offensive line that knows the count. That small, permanent edge is the offense's reward for owning the snap.

The hard count

A **hard count** is a cadence with an extra-loud, rhythm-breaking word that is *not* the snap. The quarterback barks "*HUT*" exactly the way he does when the ball really is coming, and hopes a keyed-up defender jumps. If one does, the offense gets five free yards; if the defender gets all the way across, the offense may get much more (see offside, below).

A hard count only works with the voice. A quarterback who jerks his head, shoulders or hands to fake a snap is flagged for a false start himself, because the rule against movement that imitates the snap applies to him too.¹⁰ And defenses can't play the game back: a defender who shouts fake signals to confuse the offense's count, or makes sudden movements designed to make a blocker flinch, can be flagged for "disconcerting signals."¹¹

The hard count has a famous situational use. On fourth-and-short, offenses that have no intention of going for it will sometimes line up as if they will, use a long, rhythmic hard count to try to draw the defense offside, and if nobody bites, take a delay of game penalty or a timeout and punt. You'll see this in Predict the play 3.

The four pre-snap fouls

Here are the four penalties the cadence game produces. Before the snap, the ball's position defines a strip called the **neutral zone**: the space between the offense's line of scrimmage (through the back tip of the ball) and the defense's (through the front tip), about eleven inches wide. Before the snap, only the center may be in it. Everything else hinges on who moves first and whether he touches anyone.

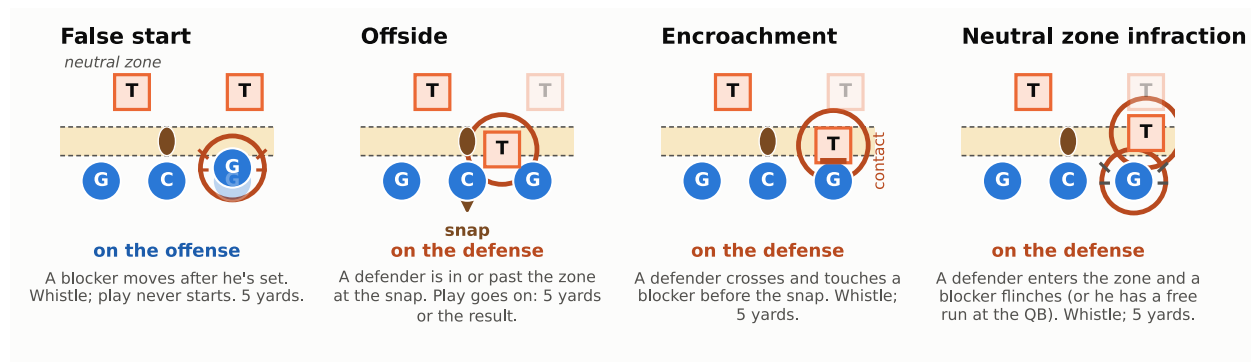


Figure 4: The four common pre-snap fouls around the neutral zone (shaded; drawn far wider than the real eleven inches so you can see it). Blue circles are the center (C) and guards (G); orange squares are defensive tackles (T). Faded markers show where a player started. False start is on the offense; the other three are on the defense. Offside is the only one where the play goes on.

- **Offside** is a defender in or beyond the neutral zone when the ball is snapped. The officials **let the play run**, and the flag waits. Afterward the offense chooses: take five yards, or keep whatever the play produced. Because the offense can't lose, a quarterback who sees a defender jump across and the flag fly often throws deep, a gamble with no downside called a free play.
- **Encroachment** is a defender who crosses into the neutral zone and touches an offensive player (or the ball) before the snap. The whistle blows immediately: five yards.
- A **neutral zone infraction** is a defender who moves into the neutral zone before the snap and makes an offensive player near him react (the classic case is a guard or tackle flinching to protect himself), or who has a clear, unblocked path to the quarterback. The whistle blows; five yards on the **defense**, and the blocker who flinched is not charged with a false start.¹²

¹⁰NFL Rulebook, Rule 7, Section 4 (false start includes a quarterback under center making a quick, abrupt movement that simulates the snap): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>.

¹¹NFL.com, "2025 rulebook, part 2," listing "disconcerting acts or signals" (12-3-1(i)) at fifteen yards: <https://www.nfl.com/news/2025-rulebook-part-2>.

¹²NFL Football Operations, video rulebook, "Neutral Zone Infraction" (a defender who enters the neutral zone and causes an offensive player in close proximity to react immediately, or who is beyond the neutral zone with an unimpeded path to the quarterback or kicker; if no player reacts and the defender gets back before the snap without contact, there is no foul): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/neutral-zone-infraction>

Note what *isn't* a foul. A defender may jump into the neutral zone and get back to his side before the snap without penalty, as long as he touched nobody and no blocker reacted. That's why you'll sometimes see a defensive end lunge, freeze and scramble back, and no flag comes.

! Why it exists: the flinch rule

Why charge the *defense* when the blocker is the one who moved? Because otherwise the defense could draw false starts at will: a lineman lunges at a tackle's face, the tackle instinctively flinches, and the offense loses five yards for protecting himself. Before the neutral zone infraction existed as its own foul, officials had to sort out which side caused which movement; the modern rule settles it: if a defender comes into the zone first and a blocker reacts, the defense started it. The trade-off is a judgment call for the officials on every flinch (did the blocker react to the defender, or did he just jump?), which is one reason pre-snap fouls can look inconsistent from week to week.

How common is all this? Very. **False start is one of the two most-called fouls in football.** In the 2025 regular season it was flagged 658 times, about 2.4 per game, a hair behind offensive holding.

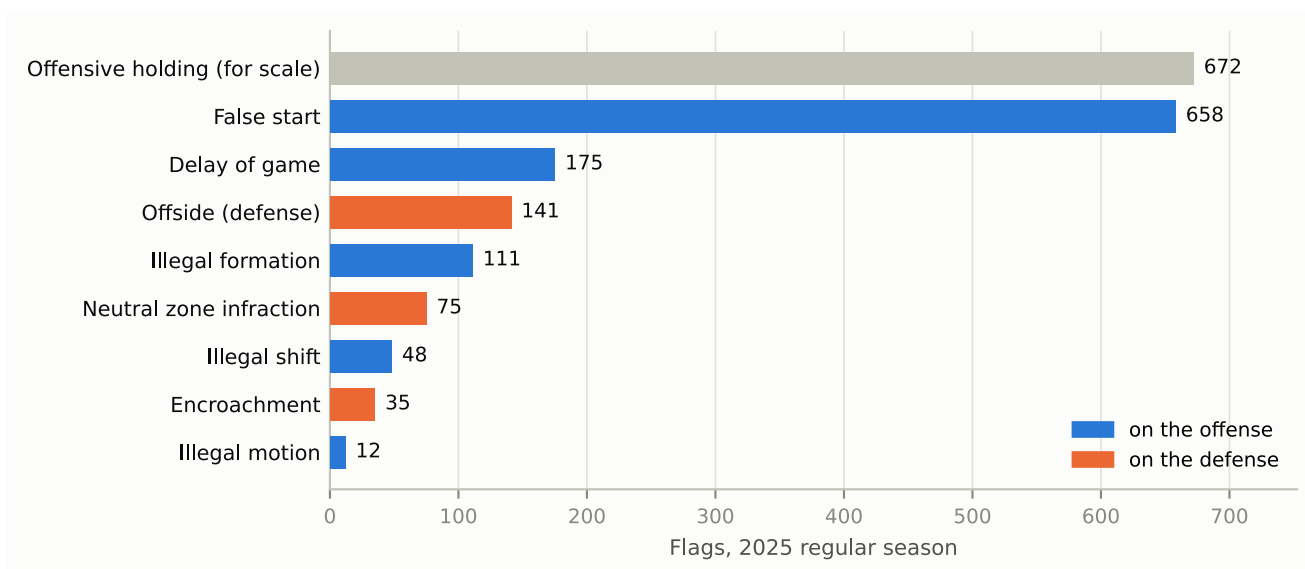


Figure 5: Pre-snap fouls flagged in the 2025 NFL regular season (272 games), with offensive holding, the most-flagged foul of any kind, for scale. Blue fouls are on the offense, orange on the defense. False start is nearly as common as holding; the defense's three ways of jumping (offside, neutral zone infraction, encroachment) add up to about 250. Illegal formation (players not lined up legally) is explained in Part 2; delay of game in chapter 1.4. Source: nflverse play-by-play, [penalty_type](#); all plays including kicks.

The chart makes a point that's easy to miss on TV: **the offense commits far more pre-snap fouls than the defense.** Owning the snap is an advantage, but it also means the offense carries all the risk of moving early. Eleven players have to hold perfectly still while a crowd screams and a defensive tackle stares them down, and a single twitch costs five yards.

No quarterback of the last two decades was more associated with the hard count than Aaron Rodgers in Green Bay. Opposing coaches spent game-week practices on it, and Packers coverage of the era described how often Rodgers turned a jumping defender into a deep shot on a free play.¹³ The play-by-play shows the effect clearly.

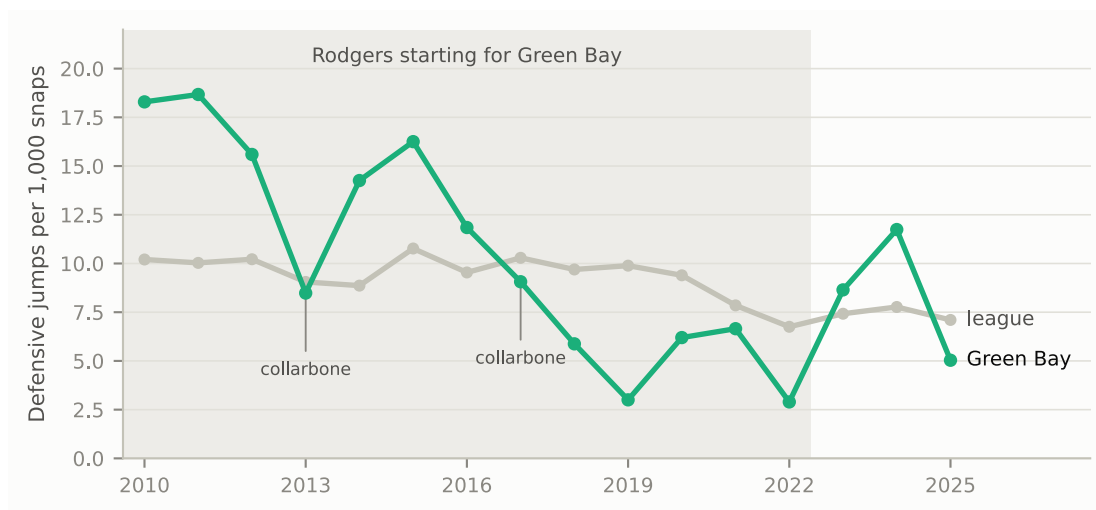


Figure 6: Defensive pre-snap fouls drawn (offside, encroachment, neutral zone infraction) per 1,000 offensive snaps, Green Bay against the league average, 2010–2025 regular seasons; plays in punt and field-goal formation excluded. Shaded: seasons Aaron Rodgers was Green Bay’s starter. The two dips inside the shading, 2013 and 2017, are the two seasons he missed about half of with a broken collarbone. Source: nflverse play-by-play; course calculation.

What to notice: from 2010 through 2015 the Packers drew a defensive jump about once every 66 snaps, roughly 1.5 times the league rate, and ranked in the top five in five of those six seasons. In the games Rodgers started in that stretch the rate was about 16 per 1,000 snaps; in the ten he didn’t, about 10, right at the league average.¹⁴ Then the edge faded: from 2018 the Packers were at or below average most years, even with Rodgers. The data can’t tell you why. Defenses may have drilled harder on ignoring his voice, the Packers may have leaned on it less, or both. But that’s the life cycle of most edges in this book: something works, opponents adjust, and it stops working.

The silent count

A cadence only works if the players can hear it, and in an NFL stadium the home crowd is doing its best to make sure the visitors can’t. When the noise wins, the offense switches to a **silent count**. No words at all: the quarterback gives a signal (often a raised leg or a clap, though teams vary it), a lineman next to the center passes it on with a tap if the center can’t see it, and the center snaps the ball after an agreed number of beats that every lineman counts in his head. Many centers also give a final cue of their own, such as lifting their head. The Eagles’ right guard Brandon Brooks once described his job in it as “the guy who communicates between the quarterback and the center.”¹⁵

The silent count solves the noise problem and creates two others. First, **the offense gives up the hard count**: with no voice there’s nothing to jump at, so the defense loses its fear of guessing wrong and can tee off on the ball. Second, the snap becomes **more predictable**: if the center always snaps a fixed beat after his head comes up, a sharp defensive line can learn that beat. Teams fight that by varying the number of beats, but they can’t vary it much without risking their own false starts.

¹³Packers.com, “Packers pounce, opponents pay on free plays”: <https://www.packers.com/news/packers-pounce-opponents-pay-on-free-plays-19370180> ; Rob Demovsky, ESPN, “Free plays: How Aaron Rodgers and the Packers offense make defenses pay”: https://africa.espn.com/blog/nfcnorth/post/_id/72180/free-plays-how-aaron-rodgers-and-the-packers-offense-make-defenses-pay ; Denver Broncos, “To contain Aaron Rodgers, start with limiting the free stuff”: <https://www.denverbroncos.com/news/to-contain-aaron-rodgers-start-with-limiting-the-free-stuff-16187870> .

¹⁴Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons 2010–2015: Green Bay drew 92 defensive offside, encroachment and neutral zone fouls (excluding punt and field-goal formations) in 6,063 run and pass plays, 15.2 per 1,000, against a league rate of about 9.8; ranked 4th, 1st, 5th, 16th, 4th and 5th by season. Splitting by games in which Aaron Rodgers threw at least ten passes: 15.8 per 1,000 snaps in 86 games with him, 10.4 in the 10 without him (a small sample). Rodgers’s broken collarbones: November 2013 and October 2017 (Pro Football Reference, Aaron Rodgers game logs: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/R/RodgAa00.htm>).

¹⁵Dave Spadaro, Philadelphia Eagles, “The silent count, and how it needs to work on Sunday” (Jan. 10, 2019), quoting guard Brandon Brooks (“When Nick is ready, he gives me the signal and I tap Kelce”; the signal “could be a hand signal. It could be a hand clap”): <https://www.philadelphiaeagles.com/news/the-silent-count-and-how-it-needs-to-work-on-sunday>

What does crowd noise actually do to pre-snap fouls? Common wisdom says road teams commit more false starts. The data says something more interesting.

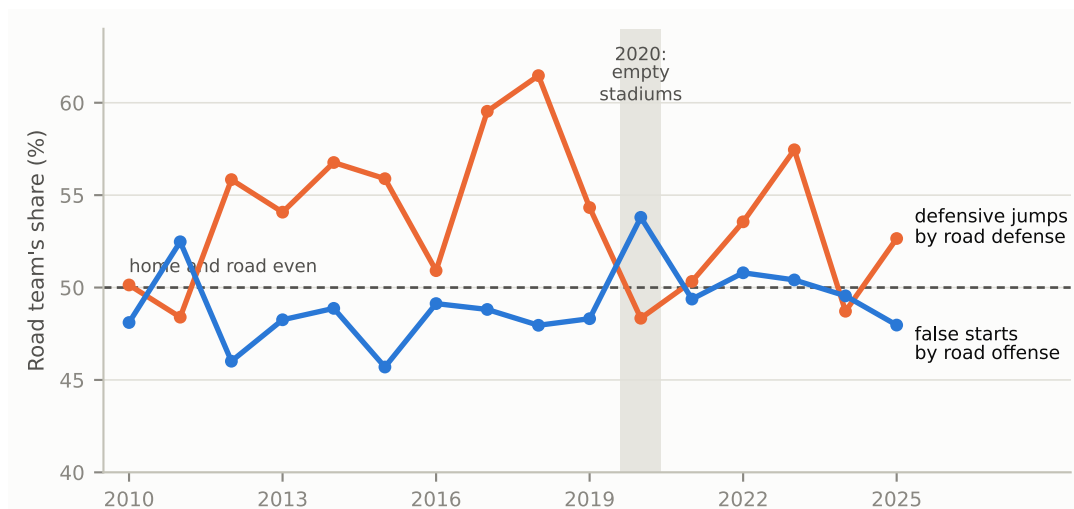


Figure 7: Share of pre-snap fouls committed by the road team, 2010–2025 regular seasons (neutral-site games excluded). Orange: defensive jumps (offside, encroachment, neutral zone infraction) by the road defense. Blue: false starts by the road offense. Above the dashed 50% line, the road team commits more than the home team. 2020, when most games were played in empty or nearly empty stadiums, is marked. Single seasons are noisy (a few hundred fouls each), so look at the pattern, not any one point. Source: nflverse play-by-play; course calculation.

Two patterns stand out, and both fit the cadence story better than the “noise makes the visitors jump” story:

- **Road offenses don’t false-start more than home offenses.** From 2010 to 2019 they committed about 48% of false starts, slightly *fewer* than the home team. A plausible reason: the silent count works. A road offense on a silent count snaps on a fixed rhythm with no hard counts, so there’s little to trick its own linemen, while a home offense, free to use its full cadence, also occasionally fools itself.
- **Road defenses jump more.** Over the same seasons, road defenses committed about 55% of the offside, encroachment and neutral zone fouls. The home offense, in a stadium that goes quiet for it, gets to use its hard count; the visiting defense is the one that has to resist it.

Then look at 2020, when most games were played in empty stadiums. Both patterns flipped: road defenses committed only about 48% of the jumps, and road offenses about 54% of the false starts. With no crowd, the visitors could use their own cadence, and they both drew and committed fouls like a home team. The crowd’s real effect, in other words, isn’t to rattle the visiting offense into moving. It’s to **take the visiting quarterback’s voice away**, and with it his best weapon against the defense.

i Film room: Eagles 2023 — a silent count at home

Usually the silent count is a road tool. The 2023 Eagles needed it at home. Lincoln Financial Field was loud enough, *while Philadelphia had the ball*, that players said they couldn’t hear Jalen Hurts’s cadence or his audibles; left tackle Jordan Mailata said the team had to use a silent count “a fair bit” even at home, and center Jason Kelce said “it would be nice if you could hear yourself think out there.” Through Week 16 the Eagles had 22 false starts, sixth-most in the league, and 15 of them had come at home.¹⁶ The play-by-play confirms the season-long split: 23 false starts, 15 at home and 8 on the road. Hurts summed it up: “It kind of gets loud for the offense. It’s supposed to get loud for the defense.”

What to notice: noise doesn’t care which jersey it’s for. When fans don’t know to quiet down for their own offense, the home team inherits the visitors’ problem, and loses its cadence weapon in its own building. The Eagles’ snap timing became a story again in a different way: on the “tush push,” the short-yardage quarterback sneak with teammates shoving from behind, their linemen’s get-off was so fast that the league tightened its officiating guidance on false starts and alignment for the play in 2025 (the tush push has its own section in Part 10).¹⁷

¹⁶Marcus Hayes, *Philadelphia Inquirer*, “Eagles to fans at the Linc: Shut up (when we’re on offense)” (Dec. 28, 2023), with the Mailata, Kelce and Hurts quotes and the 22 false starts (15 at home): <https://www.inquirer.com/eagles/eagles-fans-lincoln-financial-field-20231228.html>. Season totals (23; 15 home, 8 road) are a course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2023 regular season.

Changing the play: audibles, checks and kill calls

The radio is dead. The quarterback is at the line, looking at a defense the play-caller couldn't see when he made the call. Sometimes the call is clearly wrong: a run into a defense with more defenders near the line than the offense has blockers, or a long pass against two safeties sitting deep. What can he do?

The tools have different names, and the differences matter:

- An **audible** is the general term: the quarterback changes the play at the line, by voice or by hand signal, after seeing the defense.
- A **check** is a prepared, rule-based change: “if they show this, we run that.” Checks are built into the game plan in advance. A run play might carry a built-in check to the other side if the defense overloads the call side; a pass play might check to a different protection if the quarterback sees a likely blitz (a blitz means sending more than the usual four pass rushers; Part 2 defines it properly). **Defenses check too:** a defensive call arrives with built-in answers (“if they go to three receivers on one side, check to this coverage”), and you’ll see the green-dot linebacker and the safeties shouting and signaling to each other after a shift or motion, confirming which version they’re in.
- A **kill call** is the most common modern form. The huddle call contains **two plays**, often one run and one pass, or two plays aimed at different looks. At the line the quarterback either lets the first stand, or says “Kill! Kill!” (or another code word) and the offense runs the second. Everyone already knows both plays, so the switch is one word, not a whole new call.
- A **check-with-me** system goes further: the huddle call names only the formation and tells the team that the quarterback will pick the play at the line from a small menu.

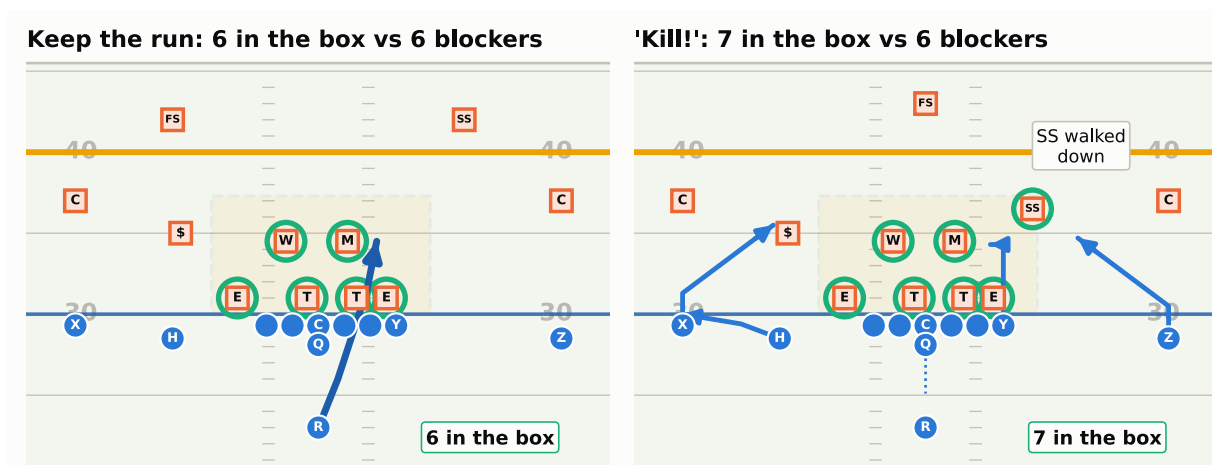


Figure 8: A kill call. The huddle call carried two plays: an inside run to the right (first) and a quick pass (second). The quarterback counts the defenders in the box (dashed rectangle): defenders lined up near the line, between and just outside the tight ends, who can get to a run quickly. Left: six in the box against six blockers (five linemen and the tight end, Y), with two deep safeties. The numbers are even, so he keeps the run. Right: the strong safety (SS) has walked down; seven in the box against six blockers. Someone will be unblocked on the run, so he says ‘Kill! Kill!’ and the offense runs the pass, against a defense that now has only four players deeper than the box.

The figure shows the most common reason for a kill call: **counting the box**. The box is the area near the ball where defenders can get to a run quickly, and comparing the number of defenders there with the number of blockers tells the offense whether a run is likely to have every defender accounted for (A First Look at Defense builds box counting properly). If the defense puts seven in the box against six blockers, one defender on a run is going to be free. But the defense paid for that seventh man by pulling him out of pass coverage, so a quick pass is suddenly the better play. The kill call lets the offense take whichever answer the defense gives it.

Why the quarterback can’t just call anything

In a video game you can audible to any play in the book at any time. Real audibles are far more limited, and the limits explain why they work the way they do.

¹⁷After the May 21, 2025 vote on banning the push failed 22–10, the league tightened officiating guidance on false starts and alignment for the play: *Sports Illustrated*, “Packers proposal to ban Eagles’ tush push fails again”: <https://www.si.com/nfl/packers/packers-proposal-to-ban-eagles-tush-push-fails-again>; *Philadelphia Inquirer*: <https://www.inquirer.com/eagles/eagles-tush-push-packers-ban-vote-20250519.html> (as summarized in the course fact sheet, §5).

i Madden vs. real life

In *Madden*, an audible swaps the whole play instantly, and your ten teammates obey perfectly. On a real field:

- **Everyone has to hear it.** A lineman who misses the change blocks the old play, and a receiver who misses it runs the old route. In a loud stadium that alone can make audibles impossible, which is why the Eagles' quarterback couldn't change plays in his own building in 2023.
- **It has to be prepared.** The quarterback can only switch to plays the team practiced for that situation that week, usually a handful per game plan, often organized as kill pairs. An audible to something the offense didn't rehearse is a recipe for a busted play.
- **It costs clock.** Every second spent changing the play is a second off the play clock, which is also why offenses that want to change plays get to the line early.
- **The defense is listening.** Everything the quarterback shouts, the defense hears too. Which is where the dummy call comes in.

Dummy calls

A **dummy call** is a word or gesture at the line that sounds like an audible but means nothing. Defenders study film and listen for patterns: if "Alabama" was followed by a run to the left three times last week, they'll want to cheat that way when they hear it. So offenses salt their calls with fakes. Some systems make a word "live" only when it follows a particular color, or only on certain downs; some have the quarterback shout a string of real-sounding calls on every play, so that the defense can never tell when a change is real. The cost is complexity for your own players, who have to know which words to listen to and which to ignore, every snap, in the noise.

i Film room: Colts 2000s — Peyton Manning's check-with-me

The most famous pre-snap operator in NFL history is Peyton Manning, whose "Omaha" we met in *What a Play Really Is*. His Indianapolis offense under coordinator Tom Moore built much of its play-calling around "check with me." Moore often sent in a formation and more than one play (reportedly two runs and a pass on many snaps), and Manning chose at the line after reading the defense. Mike Ditka, then a broadcaster, said of it in 2004: "A lot of it is 'check with me at the line of scrimmage.' Believe me, nobody could run this offense but him."¹⁸

What to notice: a check-with-me system turns the quarterback into the last play-caller, which is why it is rare. It needs a quarterback who studies like a coordinator and an offense practiced enough to execute any of the menu from the same look. Manning's pointing, shouting and pacing was a mix of real changes and dummy calls, and defenses could rarely tell which was which; that confusion was itself part of the plan. Today's offenses mostly use the more limited kill-call version, but the logic is the same: get the call in early, then let the person who can see the defense have the last word.

Naming the Mike: everyone blocks the same men

One shout you will hear before almost every snap: the quarterback or center points at a linebacker and yells something like "*Fifty-two's the Mike!*" or "*Mike, Mike, 52!*"

This isn't a guess about who the defense's middle linebacker is (the Mike linebacker is a position you already know). It's an instruction to the offense's own blockers. A protection or blocking scheme is a set of rules ("you block the first defender outside you," "you take the man over you, then the linebacker"), and rules need a reference point. By naming one defender as the "Mike" for this snap, the quarterback tells all five linemen and the back where to start counting, so they all count the same defenders and nobody blocks the same man as his neighbor while another runs free. Defenses fight this by lining up in ways that make the count ambiguous, and by moving after the Mike has been named.

¹⁸Associated Press, "Moore power," *Spokesman-Review* (Oct. 3, 2004), quoting Mike Ditka: <https://www.spokesman.com/stories/2004/oct/03/moore-power/>; on Moore often sending in "two runs, one pass" for Manning to choose from: *Washington Times*, "Manning master of the audible" (Feb. 4, 2010): <https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2010/feb/4/manning-master-audible/>.

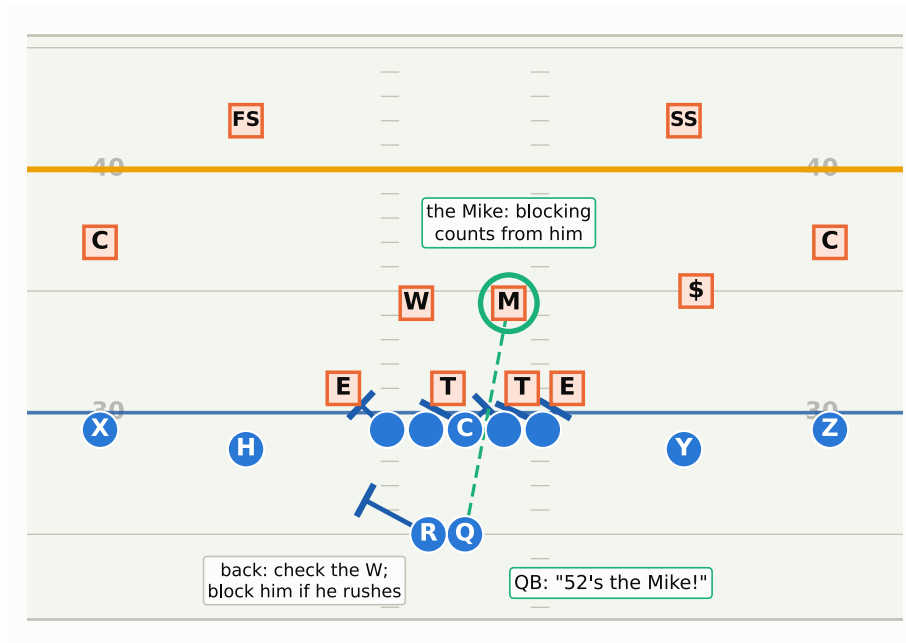


Figure 9: Naming the Mike. Before the snap the quarterback points at one linebacker (outlined) and announces him as the ‘Mike’ for this play. He isn’t necessarily the defense’s middle linebacker: he is the reference point that the protection rules count from, so all six blockers agree on who is whose. Here that puts the center and the right side on the four linemen and the Mike’s side, and leaves the back responsible for the other linebacker (W) if he rushes. How the counting works, and how defenses try to break it, is the subject of the pass-protection chapter.

The full system (protection names, how the center “slides” the line toward the Mike’s side, and what happens when the defense sends more rushers than the offense has blockers) belongs to Pass Protection. For now, the key point is that **some of the shouting at the line is the offense talking to itself**, making sure eleven people share one picture of the defense.

The defense moves too

The defense has no “set” rule. As long as nobody enters the neutral zone, defenders may move as much as they like before the snap, and good defenses use that freedom constantly. The reason is the same asymmetry in reverse: the offense knows when the ball will be snapped, so the defense’s best counter-weapon is **not letting the offense know what it’s looking at**.

You’ll see four kinds of defensive pre-snap movement:

- **Safeties walking down or rotating.** Defenses begin with some number of safeties deep, a “shell” that hints at the coverage: two deep usually means one family of coverages, one deep another (A First Look at Defense introduces shells). A safety who walks down toward the line before the snap changes the picture: more defenders near the ball, fewer deep.
- **Linebackers walking up into the line.** A linebacker who creeps up and stands in the gap between the center and a guard (the “A gap”; gap names are in The Language of the Run Game) is threatening to rush. Two of them doing it is called a double A-gap “mug,” a pressure look that gets its own treatment in Blitz and Man Pressure.
- **Shifting the front.** The defensive line slides over a gap, or the outside linebackers flip sides, often in response to the offense’s shift, sometimes on their own, just before the snap.
- **Showing blitz.** Defenders crowd the line as if they’re all coming, whether or not they are.

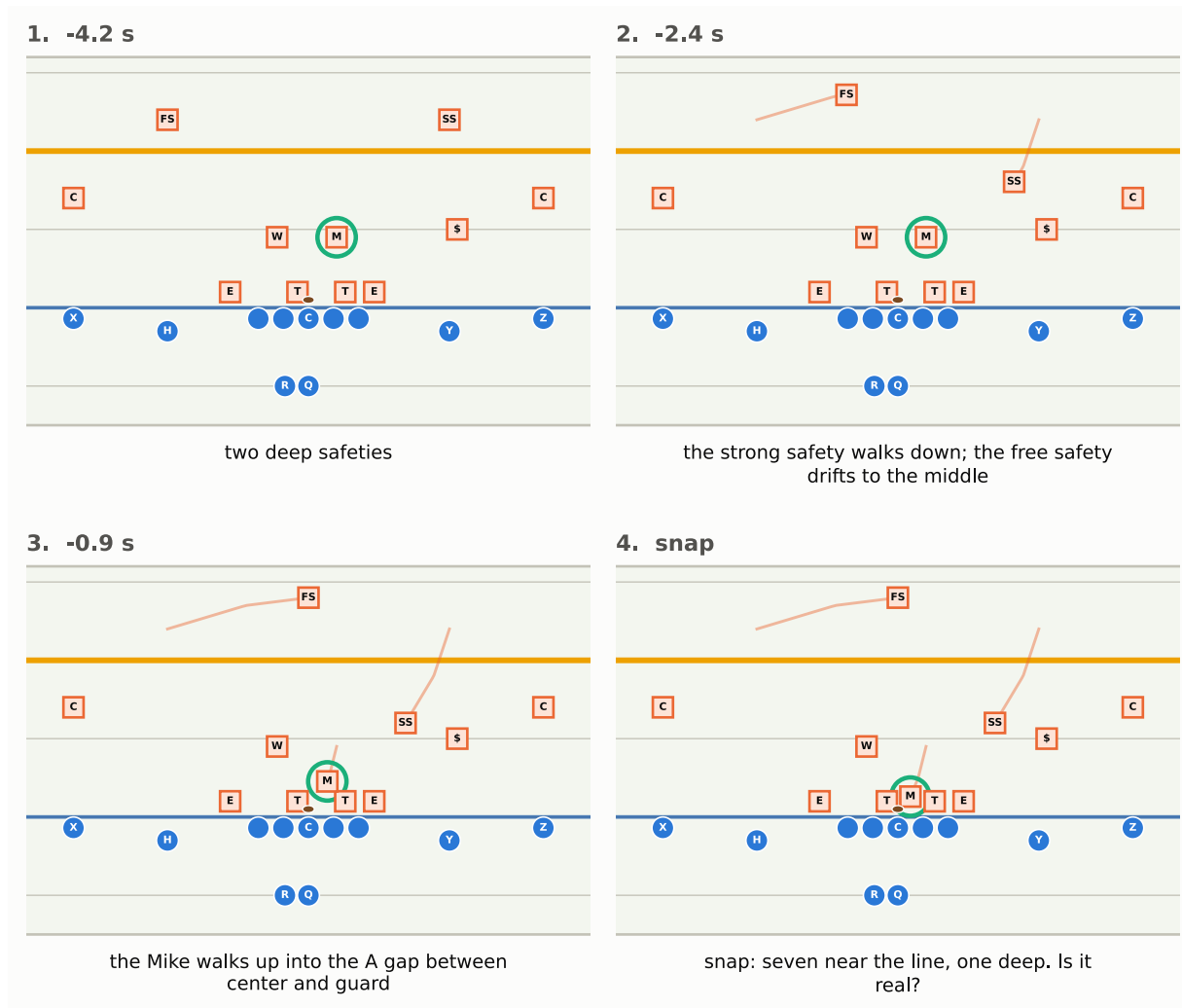


Figure 10: The defense moves, simulated. (1) Two deep safeties: the shell says one thing. (2) The strong safety (SS) walks down toward the line and the free safety (FS) drifts to the middle: now one deep. (3) With a few seconds left, the Mike linebacker (M, outlined) walks up into the A gap between the center and right guard. (4) At the snap the offense sees seven defenders near the line and one deep safety, and has to decide, in about a second, whether this is real. The offense must stay set throughout; the defense is allowed to move until the snap.

Why would a defense show its hand like this? Sometimes it isn't showing its hand at all. The movement serves one of three purposes, and the offense can't be sure which:

1. **Getting into position for the real call.** A safety who's going to cover the slot receiver or rush the quarterback has to start walking from somewhere. If he lines up in his real spot from the start, the offense reads it and checks out of trouble; so he arrives late.
2. **Disguise.** The safety walks down, the linebacker creeps into the gap, and at the snap both run back to where they started. The offense checked to a blitz-beater against a blitz that never came. Making the pre-snap picture lie about the post-snap coverage is the art of disguise, a whole late chapter.
3. **Messing with the Mike.** If the defense moves after the quarterback named the Mike, the offense's protection may be counting the wrong men. The quarterback has to re-identify, out loud, with the clock running, which is exactly the strain the defense wanted.

The trade-off for the defense is the mirror of the shift's: **every step taken late is a step taken out of position.** A safety still walking down at the snap is not where he wants to be when a receiver comes at him. A linebacker standing in the A gap who has to drop into coverage starts four yards behind where a normal linebacker would. And a defender who mistimes his creep and is in the neutral zone at the snap is offside. That's why the most dangerous defenses move *late and on time*: they hold the disguise as long as possible and still get where they're going.

What each side is trying to learn

Put it all together and the fifteen seconds before a snap become a two-way interrogation. Here's what each side is asking, and the pre-snap tools it uses to ask:

Table 1: What each side tries to learn before the snap, and how it asks.

	The offense wants to know...	The defense wants to know...
Coverage	Man or zone? One deep safety or two? (motion; watching who follows)	Which receivers will run routes, and from where? (formation, splits, motion)
Pressure	How many are coming? Who is the extra rusher? (counting the box, naming the Mike)	Who stays in to block? (where the back lines up, protection calls it can hear)
Run or pass	Is the box light enough to run? (box count, then keep or kill)	Is it a run or a pass? (personnel, formation, backfield alignment, tendencies)
Timing	Will they jump? (cadence, hard count)	When will the ball be snapped? (rhythm of the count, the center's habits)
Their rules	How do they adjust to a shift or motion?	What does this shift or motion usually lead to?

Neither side gets complete answers. The offense can't see the defense's call, only clues to it, and the defense knows it's being watched, so it hides and fakes. The defense can't see the offense's call either, and every shift, motion and dummy call is designed to make its clues less reliable. But the side that learns more in those fifteen seconds usually starts the play with the better match-up, which is why both sides work so hard at it, and why you can learn to read it from your couch.

Go deeper: pre-snap movement in real tracking data

The NFL's player-tracking data records every player about ten times a second, including before the snap, and the 2025 edition of the league's public Big Data Bowl competition was built around exactly this chapter's subject: what pre-snap movement reveals about the play to come.¹⁹ Its files mark the moment the line is set and flag every player who shifted or went in motion (columns such as `shiftSinceLineset`, `motionSinceLineset` and `inMotionAtBallSnap`). The animations in this chapter are gridiron simulations written in the same coordinates (simulated, BDB-format), so real data drops into the same drawing code. The data needs a free Kaggle login, so the cell below (in the web edition, under "Show the Python") isn't run when this book is built.

Watch for it on Sunday: count the movement

Pick two or three drives and, for each snap, keep a quick tally from the moment the huddle breaks:

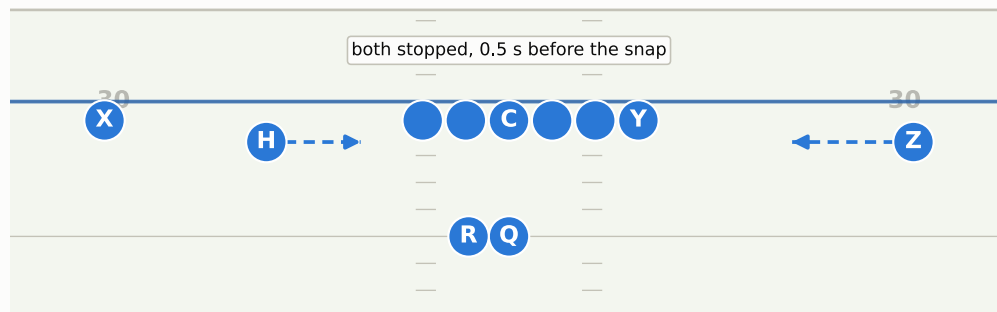
- **Offensive movers.** How many offensive players move after they first line up? Was it a **shift** (two or more at once, then a freeze) or **motion** (one man)? Did the motion man stop, or was he still moving at the snap?
- **Defensive followers.** When an offensive player moved, did any defender move *with* him? One defender trailing a receiver all the way across is a clue to man coverage; several defenders shuffling a step each is a clue to zone. Write down your guess, then check it on the replay.
- **Late defensive movement.** In the last three seconds, did a safety walk down or a linebacker creep into the line? On the replay, did he actually come, or back out?
- **The voice.** Is the quarterback pointing and shouting (a Mike call, a check, a dummy), and does anyone on the line react to it? Is the visiting quarterback using a silent count (look for the raised leg, the clap, or the guard tapping the center)?
- **The flags.** When a pre-snap flag flies, name it before the referee does: false start (offense moved), offside (defender across at the snap, play goes on), encroachment (contact), or neutral zone infraction (a blocker flinched at a defender in the zone).

¹⁹NFL Football Operations, "Big Data Bowl": <https://operations.nfl.com/gameday/analytics/big-data-bowl>. The 2025 edition (2022 season, weeks 1–9) was the first with full pre-snap tracking; column names as listed in the course fact sheet, §8.

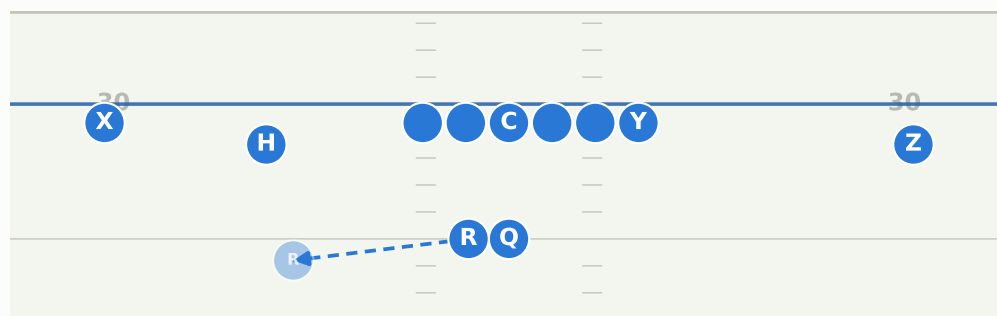
Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: flag or no flag?

A: two men move, both stop 0.5 s before the snap



B: the back is still drifting outward at the snap



C: the tight end flinches on a loud 'HUT!'

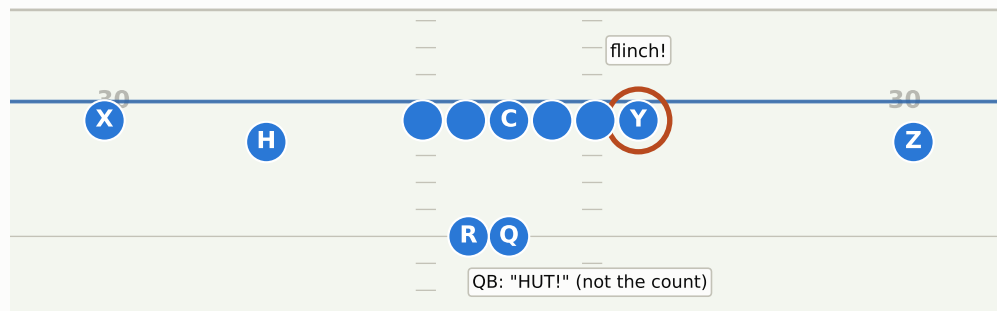


Figure 11: Three snaps from the same formation. A: two receivers move toward the ball at the same time and both stop about half a second before the snap. B: the running back motions out to the left, drifting slightly backward, and is still moving at the snap (faded circle). C: on the quarterback's loud 'HUT!', which is not the snap count, the tight end (Y, outlined) jerks his shoulders forward; nobody else moves.

Which of these draw a flag, what is it called, and who is penalized?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: run or kill?

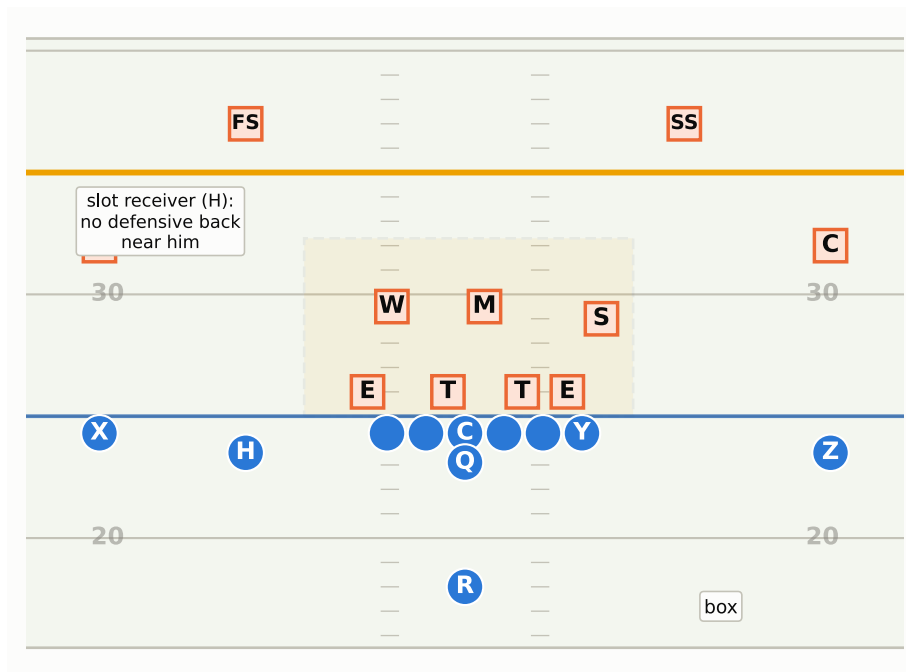


Figure 12: First-and-10. The huddle call was a kill pair: an inside run first, a quick pass to the outside receivers second. The defense stayed in its base personnel (four defensive linemen, three linebackers, four defensive backs) against the offense's three receivers. Both safeties are deep and both cornerbacks are about seven yards off their receivers. Count the box.

Does the quarterback keep the run or kill it? Why?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: fourth-and-1, four seconds left

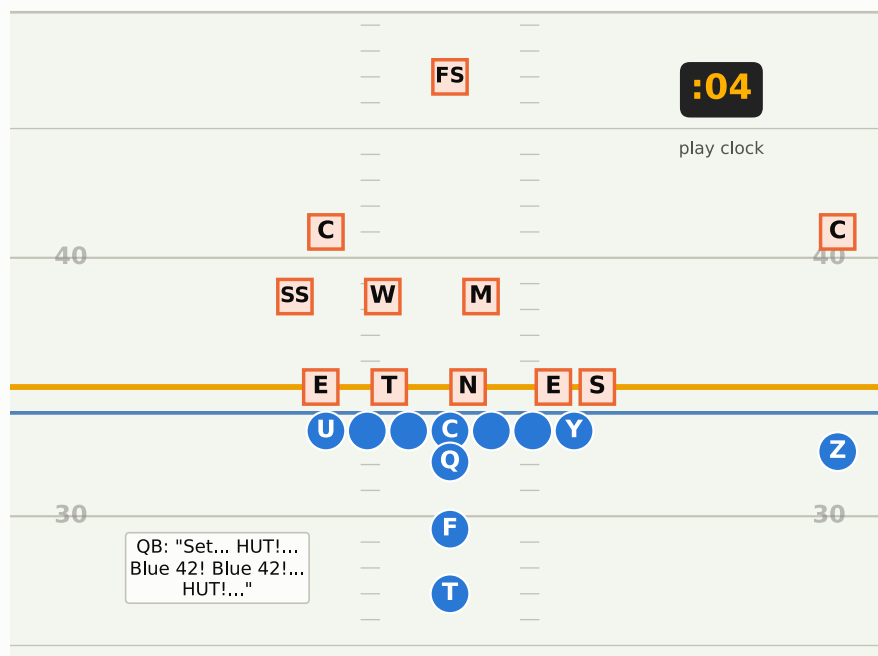


Figure 13: Fourth-and-1 from the offense's own 44, middle of the third quarter, tie game. The offense lines up in a heavy formation: two tight ends, a fullback and a tailback. Nobody shifts or motions. The quarterback has been barking a long, rhythmic cadence, his voice rising on certain words. The play clock shows :04, and on the sideline the punter is holding a ball.

What is the offense most likely doing, and what happens next if no defender moves?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- Before every snap the offense must be **set**: all eleven still for a full second. After a **shift** (two or more players moving), they must freeze again. **Motion** is one man moving; he can still be moving at the snap, but only sideways or backward, and only if he's off the line.
- The rules exist because **the offense knows when the ball will be snapped** and the defense doesn't. The set rule, the one-second freeze (from Rockne's era) and the forward-motion ban all stop that knowledge from becoming a rolling start.
- The **cadence** turns that knowledge into a small, permanent head start for the offensive line; the **hard count** tries to turn it into free yards. A **false start** is the offense moving first; **offside**, **encroachment** and **neutral zone infraction** are the defense moving first. Offside is the one where the play goes on: a free play.
- **Crowd noise takes the visiting quarterback's voice away**. A road offense on a **silent count** doesn't false-start more, but it loses its hard count, and road defenses commit more of the jumps.
- At the line the quarterback can change the play only to something prepared: an **audible**, a **check**, a **kill call** (two plays, pick one) or a **check-with-me** menu, salted with **dummy calls** because the defense hears everything. Naming the **Mike** makes sure all the blockers count the same defenders.
- The defense may move freely before the snap, and it uses that freedom to **disguise**, to arrive late in its real spots and to break the offense's count. Each side spends the fifteen seconds trying to learn more than it gives away.

Connections

Builds on: What a Play Really Is (the play call, the 40-second clock and the radio cut-off at :15 that starts this chapter's clock), The Twenty-Two (the positions, including the Mike linebacker) and Downs, Distance, and Field Position (the line of scrimmage).

Sets up: How to Watch a Broadcast Like You Mean It turns the "count the movement" habit into a full pre-snap routine. In Part 2, Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment covers who must be on the line and why; A First Look at Defense builds the

box count, blitzes and shells; and Motion and Shifts as Weapons is this chapter's sequel, on what motion actually wins. Further on: Pass Protection (Mike identification in full), Blitz and Man Pressure (A-gap mugs), Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage (how the defense's pre-snap picture lies), and Contact Rules and Penalties (the free play and penalty enforcement).

Case studies: the Eagles' trenches and the tush push, where snap timing is a weapon, and the tracking-data chapter, Tracking Data and the Big Data Bowl, where you can measure pre-snap movement yourself.

i Go deeper

- Pat Kirwan, *Take Your Eye Off the Ball* (2010; 2nd ed. 2015): the best book for fans on reading the pre-snap picture, written by a former NFL coach and scout.
- Chris B. Brown, *The Art of Smart Football* (2015): essays on how offenses build checks and kill calls into their plays.
- The NFL's own video rulebook has short clips of each pre-snap foul, which make the neutral-zone distinctions much easier to see.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

A: flag, illegal shift (offense, 5 yards). Two players moving at the same time is a shift, and after a shift all eleven must be still for a full second. Half a second isn't enough. If the offense had waited one more beat, it would have been perfectly legal.

B: legal. One man in motion, off the line (he's a back), moving away from the line and outward at the snap. Motion doesn't have to stop; it only can't be heading toward the line, and nobody else can be moving.

C: flag, false start (offense, 5 yards). The tight end is on the line, and a quick, jerky movement that imitates the snap is a false start even though he didn't cross the line. The whistle blows immediately and no play is run. Notice who *wasn't* penalized: the quarterback. A loud "HUT!" that isn't the snap is perfectly legal; that's the hard count working, except this time it fooled his own man. Had a *defender* jumped across at that "HUT!" instead, the foul would have been on the defense (offside, encroachment or neutral zone infraction depending on what he did).

Answer 2.

Kill it: throw. Count the box: four linemen and three linebackers, seven defenders, against six blockers (five linemen and the tight end). On the run, one defender will be unblocked, and he's likely to be the one who makes the tackle. The defense has paid for that: with seven near the line, only four defenders are left to cover the deeper areas, the cornerbacks are giving the outside receivers seven yards of cushion, and the slot receiver has a linebacker, not a defensive back, nearest to him. A quick pass to the outside receivers, or to the slot, attacks exactly what the defense gave up. This is the kill call's whole logic: let the defense choose where to put its seventh man, then go wherever he isn't.

One caution: everything the quarterback sees is a *pre-snap* picture. A safety can drop toward the line at the snap, or a linebacker can run out to the slot. The kill call improves the odds; it doesn't guarantee anything. Reading what happens after the snap is the subject of the passing-game chapters, starting with the pre-snap and post-snap reads of the quick game.

Answer 3.

Most likely: trying to draw the defense offside, with no intention of snapping the ball. Every tell points that way. The cadence is long and full of sharp, loud words, designed to make a keyed-up defensive lineman flinch. Nobody shifts or motions (on a real fourth-down play, offenses often use movement to create an angle or an advantage). The play clock is down to four seconds. And the punter is warming up on the sideline.

If a defender jumps, the offense gets five yards and a first down. If nobody does, the quarterback lets the play clock run out and takes a five-yard **delay of game** penalty (or calls a timeout), and the punt team comes on. Five yards hardly matter to a punt from near midfield, so the gamble costs almost nothing. As *What a Play Really Is* noted, about half of all delay-of-game flags in 2025 came on fourth down, most of them just before a punt or a field goal.

The defense's answer is simple discipline: ignore the voice, watch the ball, and don't move until it does. Defensive coaches drill this exact situation, which is why, more often than not, the trick fails and you see the punt. But it's free to try, so offenses keep trying. (Some offenses that really do want to go for it on fourth-and-1 run their actual play from the same look, so the defense can't simply assume it's a bluff. Fourth-down decision-making is in *Win Probability and Decision Analysis*.)